ENT Service Line Handbook

MERIDIAN HEALTH PARTNERS ## OPERATIONS POLICY MANUAL: OTOLARYNGOLOGY (ENT) SERVICE LINE Document ID: MHP-ENT-SOP-442 Effective Date: January 15, 2026 Applies To: All 14 Meridian Health Partners Outpatient Clinics Author: Dr. Aris Thorne, Operations Policy Lead

1. PURPOSE AND SCOPE This document establishes mandatory operational protocols for the Otolaryngology (ENT) service line across all Meridian Health Partners facilities. Compliance is mandatory for all scheduling staff, clinical intake coordinators, and attending otolaryngologists.

2. CONDITIONS ACCEPTED AND EXPLICITLY NOT ACCEPTED

2.1 Accepted Conditions
The ENT department accepts adult and pediatric patients (aged 24 months and older) presenting with the following diagnosed or suspected conditions:
* Chronic rhinosinusitis refractory to primary care management.
* Persistent conductive or sensorineural hearing loss.
* Recurrent acute tonsillitis (meeting Paradise criteria).
* Benign paroxysmal positional vertigo (BPPV) and peripheral vestibular disorders.
* Dysphonia and suspected vocal cord lesions.
* Obstructive sleep apnea (OSA) requiring diagnostic evaluation or non-surgical management.

2.2 Explicitly Not Accepted Conditions
The following conditions are outside the scope of Meridian’s outpatient ENT service line and must be redirected via direct transfer protocols to tertiary acute care facilities:
* Acute penetrating or blunt trauma to the head and neck.
* Active, profuse epistaxis requiring surgical arterial ligation or posterior nasal packing.
* Suspected or confirmed advanced-stage head and neck malignancies requiring immediate radical resection or concurrent chemoradiotherapy.
* Deep neck space infections (e.g., Ludwig’s angina, retropharyngeal abscess).
* Foreign body aspirations involving the lower respiratory tract.

3. APPOINTMENT DURATIONS All scheduling slots must adhere strictly to the following temporal allocations: * New Patient Consultations: 40 minutes. * Established Patient Return Visits: 20 minutes. * Procedure-Specific Slots (Flexible Laryngoscopy, Nasal Endoscopy, Audiometry): 30 minutes. * Post-Operative Global Period Check (Days 7–14): 15 minutes.

4. PATIENT PREPARATION INSTRUCTIONS Scheduling staff must issue the following preparation directives at the time of booking: * Vestibular Testing (VNG/ENG): Patients must cease consumption of alcoholic beverages, sedatives, and antihistamines 48 hours prior to the appointment. Fasting is required for 4 hours immediately preceding the test. * Audiometry: Patients must avoid exposure to high-intensity occupational or recreational noise (e.g., power tools, heavy machinery, personal listening devices above 80 decibels) for 14 hours prior to audiometric evaluation. * In-Office Endoscopy: No dietary restrictions apply, but patients must be informed that mild transient gagging or

epistaxis may occur.

5. INSURANCE COVERAGE MATRIX BY PLAN TIER Meridian Health Partners operates four proprietary health plans. Coverage for specialized ENT procedures is delineated below:

Procedure / Service	Meridian Core Plan	Meridian Select Plan	Meridian Premier Plan	Meridian Direct Plan
Diagnostic Nasal Endoscopy	Covered (Subject to PCP Referral)	Covered	Covered	Covered (Direct Access)
Comprehensive Audiometric Testing	Covered (Diagnostic Only)	Covered	Covered	Covered
In-Office Balloon Sinuplasty	Not Covered	Covered ($150 Copay)	Covered ($50 Copay)	Covered (Subject to Pre-Auth)
Coblation Tonsillectomy	Not Covered	Covered (Subject to Deductible)	Covered ($200 Copay)	Not Covered

6. REFERRAL TURNAROUND COMMITMENT * 6.1 Standard Referrals: The department commits to contacting the patient to schedule an appointment within 72 hours of receiving a complete referral packet. * 6.2 Urgent Referrals (e.g., sudden sensorineural hearing loss, rapid onset dysphagia without trauma): The department commits to direct telephonic contact and appointment booking within 8 hours of receipt. * 6.3 Incomplete Referrals: If clinical documentation is missing, the referral coordinator must notify the originating clinic within 24 hours; processing pauses until receipt of addendum.

Approved by:
Dr. Evelyn Vance, Chief Medical Officer, Meridian Health Partners
Marcus Sterling, Director of Clinic Operations